WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-09-21 to 2026-09-26

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SPECIAL ISSUE UPDATES

Calls checked: 2026-09-26.

Manual calls omitted pending renewed official-page verification: Public Relations Review.

Special Issue: LLM Sycophancy in Digital Journalism: News Consumption, Public Deliberation, and Governance in the Age of Conversational Agents
Digital Journalism | Deadline within 14 days | call for papers
Deadline: 2026-09-30
Official call / submission details

Special Collection: Human Behaviour Across the Globe
Nature Communications; Communications Psychology; Scientific Reports | Newly found | call for papers
Deadline: 2027-04-01
Official call / submission details

Thematic Issue: Gendered Digital Inequalities in Migration Contexts: Intersectional Approaches to Digital Inclusion
Media and Communication | Newly found | call for papers
Deadline: 2027-06-15
Official call / submission details

SUMMARY

This COMAP Journal Bot edition centers on a common problem: how people, institutions, and computational agents form judgments under mediated conditions. New work traces cross-cutting news rejection across cultures, democratic media performance across seven decades, political participation in backsliding and resilience, and the biases that structure simulated opinion dynamics among large language models.

The broader reading list connects industrial decline to gendered political backlash, administrative power to partisan punishment, and virtual-reality disclosure to embodied communication. Methodological papers on synthetic research participants, interpretable machine learning, and LLM-era reproducibility make this an especially useful week for anyone designing AI-assisted social-science research.

You may have received two September 7 emails because the first was sent before that collection window closed; the second completed the same edition. Saturday delivery now aligns collection and sending, so each future email represents a distinct Monday-Saturday edition.

HIGHLIGHTS

Disentangling interaction and bias effects in opinion dynamics of large language models

NATURE COMMUNICATIONS · 2026-09-22

Why it matters · Separates interaction effects from default-stance, agreement, and anchoring biases in LLM agent discussions, directly testing when synthetic opinion dynamics can stand in for human behavior.

Open article →

Rejection of cross-cutting news depends on content, sources, and cultural contexts: evidence from online trace data

JOURNAL OF COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-22

Why it matters · Uses online trace data from South Korea and the United States to show how content, source, and cultural context shape rejection of cross-cutting news.

Open article →

Political Actors and Their Media Practices: Analyzing the Role of Media Participation in Democratic Backsliding and Resilience

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-22

Why it matters · Recasts democratic backsliding and resilience as participatory media processes in which ordinary actors, institutions, and anonymous or false-identity accounts jointly shape political change.

Open article →

Democratic Media Performance and Democratization: A Global Longitudinal Perspective

COMMUNICATION RESEARCH · 2026-09-24

Why it matters · Longitudinal global evidence links stronger democratic media performance with later gains in electoral, participatory, and deliberative democracy while carefully limiting causal claims.

Open article →

AI cannot replace human participants in behavioral research

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-09-23

Why it matters · Draws a clear methodological boundary around synthetic respondents, a timely warning for computational social scientists considering LLMs as substitutes for human participants.

Open article →

Breadwinner backlash: The gendered effects of industrial decline

AMERICAN JOURNAL OF POLITICAL SCIENCE · 2026-09-22

Why it matters · Connects industrial decline, household breadwinner norms, and right-wing voting through local labor-market and long-run individual evidence.

Open article →

The Punitive Dimension of Presidential Particularism

AMERICAN POLITICAL SCIENCE REVIEW · 2026-09-24

Why it matters · Shows how centralized administrative power can punish electorally oppositional communities, extending presidential particularism from targeted benefits to targeted costs.

Open article →

Face-off: facial expression disclosure affects the processing of proxemic norms in virtual reality

JOURNAL OF COMPUTER-MEDIATED COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-23

Why it matters · Combines experiments, psychophysiology, and qualitative interpretation to show how visible facial expression changes the experience of interpersonal distance in virtual reality.

Open article →

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COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES
331	159	171
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES		
1		

Curated digest below: 20 new, 0 catch-up, 0 late additions

The candidate counts are the complete collected set after automated source filters and before manual relevance review; the full curated list below is the focused subset.

All 17 article sources completed. Previously delivered September 14-19 papers are not repeated; the newly indexed catch-up and late-addition candidates did not meet the COMAP relevance threshold.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

American Journal of Political Science

Breadwinner backlash: The gendered effects of industrial decline

2026-09-22 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70080

Richard Clark; Roza Khoban; Noah Zucker

Assistant Professor, Department of Politics Princeton University Princeton New Jersey USA; Associate Professor, Department of Political Science University of Notre Dame Notre Dame Indiana USA; Postdoctoral Researcher, Department of Economics University of Zurich Zurich Switzerland

Abstract. Abstract Lowskilled men have long been vulnerable to globalization, decarbonization, and other forms of economic disruption. When shocks are realized, women often increase their paid labor to compensate for men's loss of income. We study how layoffs of lowskilled men and concurrent shifts in workforce composition toward women affect voting. We theorize that this labor market rebalancing produces "nostalgic" coalitions of men and women that seek a return to malebreadwinner family models. Such attitudes fuel rightwing movements that pledge to protect conservative gender roles. Evidence from local labor markets and voting in the United States over the last two decades, as well as a longitudinal study tracking individual Americans over several decades, support this theory. These findings contribute a new genderbased account of the globalization backlash.

Read article →

American Political Science Review

Structural Injustice as Emergent Disorder

2026-09-25 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101877

HOCHAN KIM

Bates College

Abstract. Abstract Structural injustice remains a puzzling concept despite its increasing prominence. I distill recent theoretical challenges into a dilemma: either structural injustice lacks the normative credentials of injustice given that wrongdoing is inessential, or it is redundant given existing theories that trace injustice to culpable state and other institutional failures. I then develop a novel account of structural injustice, the Complexity View, that unravels this dilemma. The emergent properties of human actions in a complex society explain what is "structural" about structural injustice, specifically how it can arise without (culpable) wrongdoing. Structural injustice is unjust because it is wrong to contribute to social processes that cause harm and to passively accept preventable forms of vulnerability and deprivation as tragic misfortunes. But this account of structural injustice has a sobering implication: while complexity explains what distinguishes structural injustice from other wrongs, it also sets significant epistemic limits on social reform.

Read article →

The Punitive Dimension of Presidential Particularism

2026-09-24 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426102020

LUKAS K. ALEXANDER

Washington University in St. Louis

Abstract. Existing accounts of presidential particularism emphasize the targeted distribution of benefits to electorally valuable constituencies. This research note demonstrates that presidential particularism can also operate punitively, through the selective imposition of costs on constituencies that provided weaker electoral support for the president. I examine this dynamic through the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE), a highly centralized and politicized agency created at the start of Donald Trump's second term. Leveraging data on nearly 700,000 federal contracts linked to DOGE contract cuts and 2024 county-level election returns, I show that these cuts were systematically concentrated in counties that provided weaker electoral support for Trump. These patterns hold across contract- and county-level analyses. Together, these findings broaden theories of presidential particularism by showing that presidents may use administrative authority to impose costs on electorally oppositional constituencies. More broadly, I demonstrate how presidents can wield administrative power as a tool of partisan punishment.

Read article →

Imperial Aid and Tax Mobilization in Late Colonial Africa

2026-09-21 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101919

DIDAC QUERALT

Yale University

Abstract. In 1929, the British Empire launched a four-decade development initiative to modernize colonial economies without self-government. Known as the Colonial Development and Welfare Fund, the program required colonial administrations to raise local taxes to cofinance development projects. This article shows that imperial aid expanded colonial taxation only after organizational reforms in the Colonial Service screened in officials who shared the metropole's developmental agenda and made tax mobilization incentive-compatible with career advancement. Drawing on original data from 12 African colonies and extensive archival evidence, I show that aid increased tax revenues when patronage-based governors were replaced by career officers and promotion within the Colonial Service became conditional on fiscal performance. These findings highlight how bureaucratic incentives shaped the effectiveness of imperial aid and offer a new explanation for the expansion of fiscal capacity in late colonial Africa.

Read article →

Communication Research

Democratic Media Performance and Democratization: A Global Longitudinal Perspective

2026-09-24 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261489667

Florian Arendt

University of Vienna, Austria

Abstract. Media that effectively perform their democratic functions are widely considered a key driver of democratization, yet longitudinal evidence on their impact remains limited. This study analyzed global annual time-series data on democratic media performance and democratization from 1946 to 2018. ARIMA models indicated a covariation between annual increases in democratic media performance and gains in democratization worldwide, measured by Vanhanen's Index of Democratization. The analysis also revealed covariation with V-Dem's liberal, participatory, deliberative, and egalitarian component indices of democratic quality. Evidence on temporal ordering, consistent with Granger causality, was found for Vanhanen's index and the participatory and deliberative V-Dem component indices; evidence was marginal for the liberal component and absent for the egalitarian component. Acknowledging limitations regarding causal interpretation, the results are consistent with the claim that media can act as a leading force in democratic development rather than merely reflecting it, particularly in electoral, participatory, and deliberative dimensions.

Read article →

Journal of Communication

Rejection of cross-cutting news depends on content, sources, and cultural contexts: evidence from online trace data

2026-09-22 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG014

Wonjeong Jo; Magdalena Wojcieszak

Center for Excellence in Social Science, University of Warsaw , Warsaw,; Department of Communication, University of California , Davis, CA,

Abstract. Abstract We examine the conditions in which people reject cross-cutting news in naturalistic settings of online comments. Theoretically, we account for article content and source to test whether commenters' rejection and its intensity depend on whether cross-cutting news (a) is hostile to their in-group or favorable to the out-group and (b) is "unexpected" (from in-group sources) or "expected" (from out-group sources). Methodologically, we use online traces from news aggregators in South Korea (SK; 7,607 comments) and the United States (116,308 comments). We find that most commenters (79% in SK and 64% in the United States) reject cross-cutting news, with left-leaning commenters expressing stronger rejection than right-leaning commenters. Regarding article content, the SK commenters more strongly rejected in-group hostility, while the U.S. commenters rejected out-group favoritism more. Regarding article source, SK commenters more strongly rejected unexpected cross-cutting news from in-group sources than expected cross-cutting news from out-group sources. We discuss the implications of these findings.

Read article →

Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication

Face-off: facial expression disclosure affects the processing of proxemic norms in virtual reality

2026-09-23 · DOI 10.1093/JCMC/ZMAG021

Kun Xu; Mengsu Shi; Jiayue Li; Zhe Zhou; Yunxiao Chen; Sylvia Chan-Olmsted

College of Communication, Boston University , Boston, MA,; College of Journalism and Communications, University of Florida , Gainesville, FL,; School of Journalism and Communication, Tsinghua University , Beijing,

Abstract. Abstract As virtual reality (VR) technologies support various forms of social interactions, questions have emerged regarding whether and how interpersonal proxemic norms are enacted in VR. Meanwhile, VR's body tracking features, particularly face and eye tracking, have fostered more natural and vivid communication. However, these tracking features also intensify users' pressure to manage self-image and privacy. Drawing on lab experiments, psychophysiological measures, and qualitative interpretations, this study seeks to understand how face tracking influences individuals' cognitive and affective reactions to proxemic norm violation in VR. The findings suggest that although participants perceive proxemic norm violations as improper, physiologically arousing, and unpleasant, emerging norms in VR have subtly shifted these reactions. Participants' gender and facial expression visibility separately or jointly moderate the effects of norm violation on perceived politeness, identifiability, and social presence. The potential theoretical integration of presence, transformed social interaction, and objective self-awareness is discussed to inform future research.

Read article →

Nature

Banking records reveal characteristics of financial abuse

2026-09-23 · DOI 10.1038/S41586-026-11049-7

Anna Trendl; Nicola Sharp-Jeffs; Karen Perrier; Jane Rodrick; John Gathergood; David Leake

Abstract. Abstract The experience of financial abuse, a form of domestic abuse involving control over money and finances, can be severe and long-lasting 1-3 , yet difficult to document 4 . Evidence on the everyday experiences of victim-survivors in the context of financial abuse is drawn primarily from small-scale, qualitative surveys 5,6 . Using anonymized banking data from a major UK retail bank, we compared the financial outcomes of a group of female victim-survivors of financial abuse (n = 5,428; identified from customer disclosures to the bank) with a control group (n = 15,602; consisting of individuals with no known disclosures). The control group matched the demographic and socioeconomic characteristics of the victim-survivor group 7 years before disclosure. A comprehensive set of 373 transactional and non-transactional financial outcomes were analysed over this period. Results indicate that, compared with controls, victim-survivors exhibited depleting savings and increasing debts, culminating in missed payments and declining credit scores. They also spent less on self-care, incurred higher transport and legal costs, increased cash withdrawals, changed addresses and passwords more frequently and were more likely to claim welfare benefits. Our results demonstrate how victim-survivors lose financial independence, experience economic instability and suffer financial distress.

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Nature Communications

Building governance reform without accountability transfer invites urban disaster

2026-09-24 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-78062-2

Yasemin D. Aktas; Cassidy Johnson

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Disentangling interaction and bias effects in opinion dynamics of large language models

2026-09-22 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77340-3

Vincent C. Brockers; David A. Ehrlich; Viola Priesemann

Abstract. Abstract Large Language Models are increasingly used to simulate human opinion dynamics, yet the effect of genuine interaction is often obscured by systematic biases. We develop a Bayesian framework to disentangle and quantify three such biases: (i) A topic bias toward the LLM's default stance; (ii) an agreement bias favoring agreement to the prompted statement irrespective of the question; and (iii) an anchoring bias toward the initiating agent's stance. We apply this framework to various LLMs that performed multi-step dialogs on 12 different questions from climate change and societal justice to music preferences. We find that opinion trajectories tend to quickly converge to a shared attractor, with the influence of both interaction and biases decaying over time, and with the impact of biases differing between LLMs. In addition, we show that fine-tuning an LLM on different sets of strongly opinionated statements (including misinformation) shifts the opinion attractor correspondingly. By exposing stark differences between LLMs and providing quantitative tools for comparing interaction and bias contributions to opinion shifts in LLM agent discussions, our approach highlights both promises and pitfalls of using LLMs as proxies for human behavior.

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Mortality and healthcare services in Pennsylvania state prisons following extreme ambient temperatures

2026-09-22 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-78012-Y

Jaquelyn L. Jahn; Claudia N. Anderson; Jessica T. Simes; Leah H. Schinasi; Michael Leung; Josiah L. Kephart; Bruce Western

Abstract. Extreme temperatures pose severe risks for population health and healthcare systems. However, little research has examined implications for incarcerated populations, who may be particularly vulnerable given their limited control over their thermal environments. Here, we show that among people imprisoned in Pennsylvania (2000-2023), both warmer and cooler temperatures were significantly associated with higher rates of mortality, transfers to outside medical facilities and prison infirmary admissions, relative to outcome-specific reference minimum threshold temperatures. As temperature extremes become more frequent and severe, policy action including decarceration and the provision of accessible prison healthcare is urgently needed to protect the health of incarcerated populations. Extreme hot and cold temperatures are determinants of mortality for incarcerated populations and this manuscript shows that temperature extremes increase demand on already strained prison healthcare systems.

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Post-2020 conservation priorities are threatened by global mining

2026-09-21 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77626-6

Kaixuan Pan; Niels Raes; Wassim Le Lann; Leon Marshall; Ana Feijoo Quezada; Valerio Barbarossa; Merijn Moens; Sarah Anderson; Rene Kleijn; Jacobus C. Biesmeijer

Abstract. Abstract The United Nations has committed to halting and reversing biodiversity loss by 2030. Despite this commitment, mining remains a major driver of biodiversity decline, particularly in conservation priority zones (CPZs) and areas with high species extinction risk. Regardless of growing awareness, the full extent of current and future mining threats to biodiversity remains inadequately quantified, limiting effective global conservation strategies. Here, we quantify the threats of 145,000 km2 of current mining land to biodiversity. We find that 34% (49,000 km2) of these mining areas overlap with CPZs, intersecting the ranges of more than 2,300 species, including many classified as threatened. These threats span 14 biomes, with disproportionately high relative impacts in fragile ecosystems such as Mangroves and the Mediterranean. Furthermore, an additional 43% (12 million km2), 29% (2 million km2), and 37% (4 million km2) of land potentially exploitable for metals, non-metals, and coal, respectively, overlap with CPZs, highlighting the heightened risks from future mining expansion without consideration for biodiversity. Our findings offer actionable insights for policymakers and industry stakeholders, guiding conservation efforts to mitigate biodiversity loss and align mining practices with global conservation goals, including the UN Sustainable Development Goals and the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework.

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Nature Computational Science

Reproducibility in the era of large language models

2026-09-22 · DOI 10.1038/S43588-026-01061-2

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Nature Human Behaviour

How AI companions could deepen social inequality

2026-09-21 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02538-W

Qiyang Zhang; Renwen Zhang; Nan Liu

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Political Communication

Political Actors and Their Media Practices: Analyzing the Role of Media Participation in Democratic Backsliding and Resilience

2026-09-22 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2735919

Daniel Kreiss; Kate Wright

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Abstract. This paper draws together insights from political science and political communication to advance a new understanding of the role of media in democratic backsliding and resilience. The central argument is that all political actors may also be media actors, although they may do so anonymously or use false identities. Thus, mass participation in media enables mass participation in political change, with better and worse democratic outcomes. As such, when analyzing backsliding and resilience scholars need to move away from focusing solely on particular institutions and actors with presumed democratic functions, as well as assuming that media and expressive freedom will necessarily serve democratic ends. Instead, we advocate analyzing how the participatory media practices of various actors interact with one another via communicative structures within processes of backsliding and resilience. Participatory media practices that prevent democratic breakdown include disseminating early warnings of backsliding, exposing executive errors and corruption, coordinating pro-democratic mobilization, and platforming the opposition, as well as countering disinformation and delegitimizing democratic institutions and processes. We also indicate how participatory media practices may aid democratic bounceback, as well as the challenges involved in reimagining the media infrastructure needed to sustain democratic recovery in the long-term. Thus, we argue that democratic backsliding and resilience should be reconceptualized as profoundly participatory, mediated processes.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Dynamic attribute activation explains gaze biases in choice

2026-09-25 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2603674123

Xiaozhi Taro Yang; Sudeep Bhatia

Department of Psychology, University of Pennsylvania; School of Arts and sciences Mind Center for Outreach, Research, and Education, University of Pennsylvania

Abstract. People tend to choose the options they look at more. Prior work explains this effect by assuming that visual attention increases preference for the attended option. However, it remains unclear why looking at an option increases its preference and when this relationship is weakened. Using an experimental paradigm that combines eye-tracking and a think-aloud protocol, we provide evidence that visual attention shapes preference by activating attributes associated with the attended option. Critically, the content of these activated attributes depends on contextual factors such as stimulus desirability and behavioral goals. In standard choice settings, where the goal is to choose the preferred option, visual attention primarily activates positive attributes. In contrast, when these contextual factors are incongruent, activated attributes become less positive, reducing the influence of visual attention on choice. To account for these patterns, we propose a computational model of gaze-driven attribute activation. Our model subsumes existing theories as special cases, and uniquely predicts which attributes are brought to mind by gaze and how they shape downstream decisions. Together, our work offers a mechanistic explanation of a fundamental driver of choice as well as its boundary conditions.

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AI cannot replace human participants in behavioral research

2026-09-23 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2611363123

Jim Hoover; Alan D. J. Cooke; Geoff Tomaino; Su Hyun Lee

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Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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AICO: Feature significance tests for supervised learning

2026-09-23 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2530045123

Kay Giesecke; Enguerrand Horel; Chartsiri Jirachotkulthorn

Hasso Plattner Institute, University of Potsdam; Institute for Computational and Mathematical Engineering, Stanford University; Upstart Inc.

Abstract. Machine learning is central to modern science, industry, and policy, yet its predictive power often comes at the cost of transparency: We rarely know which input features drive a model's predictions. Without such understanding, researchers cannot draw reliable conclusions, practitioners cannot ensure fairness or accountability, and policymakers cannot trust or govern model-based decisions. Existing tools for assessing feature influence are limited; most lack statistical guarantees, and many require costly retraining or surrogate modeling, making them impractical for large modern models. We introduce AICO (Add-In COvariates), a broadly applicable framework that turns model interpretability into an efficient statistical exercise. AICO tests whether each feature contributes to predictive performance by masking its information and measuring the resulting change. The method provides exact, finite-sample feature P -values and CIs for feature importance through a simple, nonasymptotic hypothesis testing procedure. It requires no retraining, surrogate modeling, or distributional assumptions, making it feasible for large-scale algorithms. In both controlled experiments and real applications, from credit scoring to mortgage-behavior prediction, AICO identifies variables that contribute to model behavior, providing a scalable and statistically principled path toward transparent and trustworthy machine learning.

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Science

Science still has expertise; what it's lost is authority

2026-09-24 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEM5190

H. Holden Thorp

H. Holden Thorp is Editor-in-Chief of the Science journals.

Abstract. In the years since the pandemic and the political turmoil surrounding the American scientific establishment, much time has been spent discussing why science has lost influence on public policy in the United States. A time when scientific advice about vaccination, nutrition, and environmental regulation was more readily heeded seems a distant memory. Scientific expertise has been decoupled from a sense of authority and standing to dictate policy on matters ranging from public health to climate change. The explanations for this separation include the rise of technologies like the internet and artificial intelligence, mistakes made by scientists and scientific institutions, and weaponization of anti-science ideas by political actors. But what if there's a larger historical trend that suggests the disconnect between expertise and authority was inevitable? A new idea in philosophy called the "unicontext" suggests that the advance of technology, along with basic human desires, has been leading to this point for the past century.

Read article →

Science Advances

Quantifying CAHOOTS: Measuring a mobile crisis response program's impact on police response through call diversion and prevention

2026-09-25 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEB8064

Nathan Burton; Claire Herbert; Rori Rohlfs

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Abstract. Mobile Crisis Response Programs (MCRPs) have emerged as alternatives to police for emergency mental and behavioral health calls, yet their effectiveness in diverting calls from police remains contested. CAHOOTS (Crisis Assistance Helping Out On The Streets), the United States' longest-running MCRP, has been subject to widely varying ad hoc diversion rate estimates, from 3 to 20%. We use a systematic difference-in-differences design to estimate the causal effects of CAHOOTS on police call volume by introducing three estimators. The Substitution Diversion Rate (SDR) quantifies MCRP responses that directly replace police responses and estimates the rate at 18% for CAHOOTS. Our results indicate that in addition to substituting for police response, CAHOOTS was associated with reductions in police-handled call volume consistent with a prevention effect. The Prevention-adjusted Diversion Rate (PDR) accounts for both call substitution and prevention, and we estimate it at 23% for CAHOOTS. Last, the Overlapping-mandate Diversion Rate (ODR) quantifies the proportion of mutually answerable calls handled by an MCRP. We estimate CAHOOTS' ODR at 50%. Our findings provide evidence that MCRPs significantly reduce police response call volume through direct substitution and likely incident prevention.

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